

Conclusion

Are Protestors Opportunists? Fifty Tests

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THE IDEA that “political opportunities” are a necessary precondition for collective political contention has been common sense to social movement analysts for thirty years (McAdam 1982; McAdam, McCarthy, and Zald 1996a; Tarrow 1998a). Yet key questions about the causal relationship between political opportunities and the emergence of political contention remain, in part because current research on contention largely takes the form of single case studies (Crist and McCarthy 1996). Little research has systematically examined the impact of a *common* set of political opportunities; instead, authors have conceptualized such opportunities in either an idiosyncratic or post hoc fashion, hindering the cumulative acquisition of knowledge about the importance of specific kinds of opportunities. This volume has examined ten case studies in some depth, but I now wish to extend our effort to a more extensive sample.

Among the key questions that have been neglected or poorly answered in the literature are the following: Are political opportunities a significant causal factor in the emergence of *most* social movements, revolutions, and other forms of political contention? Does political contention emerge when opportunities expand? Are political opportunities *necessary* for the emergence of political contention? Are opportunities more important for the emergence of political conflict in democratic or in authoritarian political contexts? Are they more important for the emergence of some types of movements, or for the occurrence of some types of contention, than others? And which types of opportunities or

combination of opportunities are most important for the emergence of political contention and for specific types of contention?

This chapter begins to address these questions, utilizing a fifty-case data set that draws upon the research of more than forty scholars and research assistants, including the authors of the essays collected in this volume. (The analyst of each of the fifty cases is indicated in Appendix A.) This is the largest and most diverse data set yet employed, as far as I am aware, to assess the importance of political opportunities for the emergence of various types of political conflict in different political settings. These data, set forth in Appendix A, indicate among other things whether four specific political opportunities were a significant causal factor in each of the fifty cases of social movements, rebellions, revolutions, or cultural movements. These four political opportunities were taken from Doug McAdam (1996, pp. 26–29), who himself synthesized them from the existing literature (see Tarrow 1994, pp. 85–89). These opportunities are (1) increasing popular access to the political system, (2) elite divisions or conflicts, (3) the presence of elite allies, and (4) declining state repression. The hypothesis, of course, is that one or more of these opportunities is a necessary precondition for the emergence of social movements.

The Data

Before turning to the findings, a few words about the data. These fifty cases are in no sense a random sample of political contention. Random sampling of movements and rebellions is presently impossible and likely to remain so for the foreseeable future. It would require an authoritative list of all instances of movements, rebellions, and revolutions that have occurred or been attempted in a given time frame or place. No such list exists, even for the United States during the past few decades—the country and era that have been most closely scrutinized by scholars of social movements. For this reason, I have not applied standard statistical tests to the data, which are best viewed as provisional and suggestive—and as a provocation, I hope, for further comparative research in this vein. That said, I believe these data do have important implications for political-opportunity analysis and for the analysis of political contention more generally.

While the cases in the data set were not randomly selected, they were intentionally chosen to include a wide range of cases, starting with the better known (and better studied) cases of recent U.S. social movements. The sample reaches beyond political contention in the democratic capitalist societies of Western

Europe and North America to include many cases in the poorer, dependent, and frequently nondemocratic societies of Latin America, Africa, Asia, and the former Soviet bloc. Nearly half of the cases (21) occurred in the latter societies, and more than a third of the cases (18) arose in the context of an authoritarian political regime. Moreover, in addition to the social movements on which scholars of political contention have tended to focus, the sample also includes types of contention for which the causal mechanisms associated with political opportunities also presumably matter, such as rebellions, revolutions, and cultural movements. The sample includes some of the most important movements and revolutions of the past two centuries as well as numerous cases of contention that are less well known and, by most standards, of less historical importance, in order to broaden the research findings about how movements develop.

The cases of political contention in Appendix A are listed in rough chronological order. The year(s) given for each case generally refers to the year(s) when that case of contention clearly appeared or emerged *qua* collective contention, rather than to its entire historical trajectory. (The focus in this chapter is on the relationship between political opportunities and the emergence of contention; I do not address the relationships between opportunities and longer-run movement dynamics, movement forms and strategies, movement decline, or the consequences of movements.) Although the cases span more than two centuries (since 1789), all but four occurred during the twentieth century, particularly the second half. Twelve emerged before or during the Second World War; the other thirty-eight occurred afterward.

The general political context in which each case of contention arose is also given in Appendix A. This variable is introduced in order to see whether political opportunities matter more (or less) if the context in which contention occurs is democratic or authoritarian. Accordingly, I have categorized the cases into four general political contexts: DEM (democratic); DEM/NON (democratic with certain nondemocratic features, such as key groups that lack civil rights); NON/DEM (nondemocratic with democratic features, such as semicompetitive elections or limited civil and political rights); and NON (nondemocratic, which subsumes totalitarian, post-totalitarian, single-party, military, and personalist dictatorships). These are fairly crude distinctions, and a more differentiated schema of political regimes could as easily be employed, but this is unnecessary for the limited purposes of this study.

I have also roughly categorized each case into three general types of political contention: REB (rebellions and revolutions, which seek to displace existing

political authorities and/or pursue their goals violently or coercively); REF (reform movements, which make demands on but do not seek to displace existing government authorities or other power holders, generally nonviolently); and CUL (cultural movements, which challenge dominant cultural codes or norms or the beliefs and values of specific groups). The purpose here is to see whether political opportunities matter more or less depending upon how groups generally contend with other groups, including but not limited to state officials. These categories represent ideal types that may combine in empirical cases; in such instances, I have listed two (or even all three) types in the order in which the case best approximates these types. For example, I have described the U.S. "homophile" movement of the 1950s (case 13 in Appendix A; also Chapter 7) as primarily a reform movement, but with elements of a cultural movement (hence, "REF/CUL"). Again, one could apply a more differentiated and fine-grained analytical schema to the data, but this is unnecessary for our present, limited purposes.

The key data indicate whether McAdam's four political opportunities were judged to be causally significant for the emergence of each case of contention. In Appendix A, a "1" in one of the four columns under "political opportunities" indicates that a causal mechanism related to that opportunity was found to be clearly important by the analyst of the movement; a "0" indicates that no such mechanism was judged important. Each case, accordingly, can be summarized by a four-digit string of numbers that indicates which of the four opportunities, in the order listed above, were causally significant. The civil rights movement in Mississippi (case 17; also Chapter 5), for instance, can be summarized by the numerical string "0110," which indicates that elite divisions and elite allies (but not the other two opportunities) were important for the emergence of this movement. The Iranian Revolution of 1978–79 (case 31), to take another example, can be summarized by "0000," which indicates that none of the four opportunities factored in the emergence of that revolutionary movement.

The coding of political opportunities necessarily rests upon a number of interpretive judgments by the analysts involved in this project—judgments about not only when a given case of contention can be said to have arisen or emerged, but also how exactly McAdam's list of political opportunities should be operationalized and (not least) whether there is convincing evidence that one or more political opportunities were causally significant. There are, at present, no agreed-upon techniques for addressing the last two

issues in particular. (The precise instructions provided to researchers are given in Appendix B.)

The broadly interpretive as opposed to technical nature of researchers' findings about political opportunities is another reason for treating these data as tentative and suggestive rather than definitive. Scholars evaluating the same empirical facts may reach very different conclusions about the importance of political opportunities for any given case of political contention. It is inevitable that the "intercoder reliability" of the findings about political opportunities must be judged relatively low for this project, as several researchers noted to me, because the concepts and causal mechanisms associated with political-opportunity analysis are often only vaguely defined or specified and because there is no consensus about how to operationalize these mechanisms for empirical analysis (see Meyer and Minkoff 1997).

Two other data categories are included in Appendix A: (1) additional pertinent information, listed under "Notes," including evidence for political-opportunity mechanisms other than those emphasized by McAdam as well as evidence for "contracting" political opportunities (or what might be conceptualized as "threats"), and (2) the monographs, chapters or journal articles utilized by analysts as the principal source(s) for making a determination about the relevance of specific political opportunities.

Findings

Are political opportunities a causal factor in the emergence of most social movements, revolutions, and other forms of political contention? Does political contention emerge in a context of "expanding" opportunities?

Our data suggest that political opportunities are indeed a causal factor of some significance in most cases of political contention. One or more political-opportunity was a factor in the emergence of 31 of our 50 cases of contention (62 percent). When cultural movements—which do not fit all definitions of social movements or political contention—are removed from the sample, political opportunities are a factor in about two-thirds (67.4 percent) of the remaining cases (see Table C.1, indicating the number of cases that correspond to each of the sixteen possible combinations of the four political opportunities).

Surprisingly, "contracting" opportunities—specifically, declining access to the polity and/or intense or increasing repression—were important factors in many of these cases. In the 31 cases for which political opportunities mattered,

TABLE C.1 Patterns of Political Opportunities

	All cases	All cases except cultural (or primarily cultural) movements
	n=50	n=43
ABCD		
0000	19	14
0110	11	10
0010	4	4
0100	4	3
1110	3	3
1111	3	3
0111	1	1
0101	1	1
0011	1	1
1100	1	1
1010	1	1
0001	1	1
1000	0	0
1001	0	0
1101	0	0
1011	0	0
Percentage of cases in which political opportunities were judged causally important:		
	All cases	All cases except cultural (or primarily cultural) movements
	62.0 (n=31)	67.4 (n=29)

KEY: A=increasing access to the political system; B=elite divisions or conflicts; C=elite allies; D=declining repression.

contracting opportunities were important in more than a third (n=12). In other words, the emergence of contention in these cases was partly a result of simultaneously expanding *and* contracting political opportunities. Thus, well under half of the cases of contention in our sample (19 of 50, or 38 percent) emerged in a context of exclusively expanding political opportunities (19 of 43, or 44 percent of the cases, if we exclude cultural and primarily cultural movements).

Are political opportunities necessary for the emergence of political contention?

As noted at the outset, many analysts of social movements explicitly or implicitly suggest that expanding political opportunities are necessary, albeit not sufficient, for the emergence of social movements and kindred forms of political contention. According to McAdam, McCarthy, and Zald, political opportunities are a "necessary prerequisite" to movements and revolutions because they "render the established political order more vulnerable or receptive to challenge" (1996a, p. 8). Tarrow suggests that "changes in political opportunities and constraints create the *most important* incentives for initiating new phases of contention" (1998b, p. 7; emphasis added). Our data suggest that such claims are exaggerated. As Table C.1 indicates, a significant proportion of the cases of contention in our sample—nearly four in ten—did not occur due to political opportunities. Even when cultural movements are removed from the sample, nearly a third of the remaining cases arose because of factors other than political opportunity. The set of cases for which political opportunities were not important includes several powerful movements and revolutions, including the anti-Vietnam War movement in the United States, the Iranian Revolution of 1978–79, and the Chinese democracy movement of 1989.

Our data suggest another reason to reject the notion that political opportunities are necessary for the emergence of contention: in many cases in which they were causally important, it is difficult to claim that contention would not have occurred on a large scale in their absence. Indeed, any number of factors may encourage or facilitate contention without being strictly obligatory or indispensable. Consider the debate between James Jasper and Christian Smith regarding the U.S. Central America peace movement of the 1980s (Chapter 8). Smith argues, convincingly in my view, that this movement would not have been as large and effective as it was without elite allies in Washington (specifically in the U.S. Congress). Yet Jasper is equally convincing in his claim that elite allies were not a significant factor behind the initial emergence of this movement and that considerable protest against the Reagan administration's policies in Central America would have occurred even if Congress had unanimously supported those policies. As Smith himself notes, "the majority of the activists [in the peace movement] became involved because they believed it was the right and necessary thing for them to do, *whatever the outcome*, and not primarily because they calculated that the probable consequences of their individual participation warranted their involvement and justified the costs it would entail" (Smith 1996, p. 195; Smith's emphasis). Thus, even if one

agrees with Smith that elite allies were a significant political opportunity for the growth of this movement, it does not follow that they were necessary for its emergence.

Or consider the nativist and anti-slavery "Know Nothing" movement in the United States of the mid-1850s. Tyler Anbinder's (1992) outstanding study demonstrates that elite allies (of a sort) were an important factor in the explosive growth of this movement in 1854. Specifically, Anbinder notes that many Protestant ministers in rural areas "used the Know Nothings as a means to exert political influence. Not all ministers supported Know Nothingism, but the impression that many religious leaders sympathized with its goals helped the Know Nothings attract members outside of nativism's traditional urban strongholds" (1992, pp. 49–50). Anbinder is equally clear, however, that the movement had a substantial urban base and was attractive primarily because it provided an anti-slavery alternative to the dominant Whig and Democratic parties. The movement would certainly have been very powerful, accordingly, perhaps even in rural areas, with or without the help of Protestant ministers (although whether these ministers should count as "elite allies" external to the movement is a serious question).

Political opportunities, in sum, are not always necessary for the emergence of political contention, even when they contribute to it in some significant way.

Are political opportunities more important for the emergence of political conflict in democratic or in nondemocratic political contexts?

The data strongly suggest that political opportunities are much more likely to matter for the emergence of political contention in nondemocratic than in democratic societies. In democracies, one or more political opportunity was a causal factor in the origins of contention in less than half of the cases (40.9 percent); in nondemocratic contexts, by contrast, political opportunities were important in more than four-fifths (83.3 percent) (see Table C.2). We find the same pattern in "mixed" political contexts. Political opportunities were causally significant in only 41.7 percent of the cases of contention that emerged under democratic regimes with or without important nondemocratic features; by contrast, political opportunities mattered in 80.8 percent of the cases of contention that arose under nondemocratic regimes with or without important democratic elements.

These findings bear out the hypothesis that *changing* political opportunities are likely to matter less for the emergence of political contention in democracies than under authoritarian regimes because the former tend, by definition,

TABLE C.2 Patterns of Political Opportunity in Different Political Contexts

	All cases	DEM	DEM/NON	NON/DEM	NON
	n=50	n=22	n=2	n=8	n=18
ABCD					
0000	19	13	1	2	3
0110	11	3	0	4	4
0010	4	1	0	0	3
0100	4	2	0	1	1
1110	3	1	1	0	1
1111	3	1	0	1	1
0111	1	0	0	0	1
0101	1	0	0	0	1
0011	1	0	0	0	1
1100	1	0	0	0	1
1010	1	1	0	0	0
0001	1	0	0	0	1
1000	0	0	0	0	0
1001	0	0	0	0	0
1101	0	0	0	0	0
1011	0	0	0	0	0
Percentage of cases in which political opportunities were judged causally important:					
	All cases	DEM	DEM/NON	NON/DEM	NON
	62.0	40.9	50.0	75.0	83.3
		DEM + DEM/NON		NON/DEM + NON	
		41.7		80.8	

SOURCE: Derived from Appendix A. KEY: DEM=democratic; DEM/NON=democratic with important nondemocratic features; NON/DEM=nondemocratic with some democratic features; NON=nondemocratic (see text for explanation).

to tolerate many types of nonviolent political contention. Democracies are "structurally open," so to speak, to a variety of forms of contention. Under democracies, accordingly, the outbreak of contention is as likely to be a result of suddenly imposed (or perceived) grievances or fears, moral shocks, new collective identities, and/or the development of social ties and organizations among aggrieved populations as of changing political opportunities. By contrast, political opportunities are likely to matter more under authoritarian regimes for the simple reason that many forms of protest are routinely repressed under

such regimes. Given their tendency to rely upon force and threats, authoritarian regimes generally need to be "shaken up" in some fashion before people will undertake risky protest. Those fighting for citizenship rights need openings that those who already have such rights do not (Jasper 1997).

There is an irony to these findings. Political opportunity and political-process theorists have been criticized for developing their ideas about contention exclusively from the histories of Western European and North American societies, neglecting the experiences of the Third World. Some have implied that political-opportunity theory is less applicable—or even inapplicable—to the Third World because of this alleged Eurocentric bias. Our findings indicate, however, that political-opportunity analysis is actually more illuminating of contention outside of Europe and North America to the extent that authoritarian regimes historically have been more prevalent in poorer and dependent Third World societies.

Are political opportunities more important for the emergence of some types of movements or conflict than for others?

Table C.3 indicates the prevalence of the various patterns of political opportunities for each of the three general types of contention in the sample. I have given each type of contention a loose and a strict definition for this purpose. The former (summed in column 1) includes all cases that fit each type in some significant manner. For example, the findings about political opportunities for the U.S. homophile movement (case 13) are included under the loose definition of cultural movements, even though this was primarily a reform movement. By contrast, only "pure" cases of each type are included under the strict definition (summed in column 2). Thus, the findings for the Cuban Revolution (case 14), for example, are included under the strict definition of rebellions and revolutions (column 2) as well as under the loose definition of this type of contention (column 1).

Political opportunities tend to matter most for the emergence of rebellions and revolutions, loosely defined (90.9 percent of all such cases), and to matter least for cultural moments, strictly defined (0 percent), with reform movements falling in between. Interestingly, political opportunities were important for the emergence of fewer than half the reform movements, strictly defined (46.2 percent).

Rebellions and revolutions tend to occur under, and typically against, authoritarian regimes, whereas reform movements tend to occur under democratic regimes—and the emergence of contention, as we have just seen, is more

TABLE C.3 Patterns of Political Opportunity by Type of Contention

	All cases		REB		REF		CUL	
	(1)	(2)	(1)	(2)	(1)	(2)	(1)	(2)
	n=50	n=43	n=22	n=16	n=28	n=13	n=18	n=4
ABCD								
0000	19	14	2	2	13	7	10	4
0110	11	10	6	3	7	4	2	0
0010	4	4	3	3	1	0	1	0
0100	4	3	4	1	2	0	2	0
1110	3	3	2	2	1	0	1	0
1111	3	3	1	1	2	1	1	0
0111	1	1	1	1	0	0	0	0
0101	1	1	0	0	1	1	0	0
0011	1	1	1	1	0	0	0	0
1100	1	1	1	1	0	0	0	0
1010	1	1	0	0	1	0	1	0
0001	1	1	1	1	0	0	0	0
1000	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
1001	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
1101	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
1011	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0

Percentage of cases in which political opportunities were judged causally important:

All cases		REB		REF		CUL	
(1)	(2)	(1)	(2)	(1)	(2)	(1)	(2)
62.0	69.8	90.9	87.5	53.6	46.2	44.4	0.0

KEY: REB=rebellion or revolution; REF=reform movement; CUL=cultural movement.
(1)=loose definition; (2)=strict definition. See text for explanation.

dependent upon changing political opportunities under authoritarianism than in democracies. Contention tends to be channeled into rebellious and revolutionary forms under authoritarian regimes, whereas it is more likely to be reformist under democracies. In other words, political opportunities would seem to matter more for rebellions and revolutions than for reform movements because the former are more likely to occur under (and against) authoritarian regimes. In fact, as Table C.4 indicates, 88.9 percent of the rebellions and revolutions in our sample (or cases judged to be primarily rebellions or revolutions, with secondary attributes of other types) emerged under *nondemocratic*

TABLE C.4 Types of Contention in Different Political Contexts

Type of contention	Political context		Total (row)
	DEM or DEM/NON	NON or NON/DEM	
REB (or primarily REB)	2 (10.5%) (11.1%)	16 (66.7%) (88.9%)	18 (100%)
REF (or primarily REF)	17 (89.5%) (68.0%)	8 (33.3%) (32.0%)	25 (100%)
Total (column)	19 (100%)	24 (100%)	43

KEY: DEM=democratic; DEM/NON=democratic with important nondemocratic features; NON=nondemocratic; NON/DEM=nondemocratic with some democratic features; REB=rebellion or revolution; REF=reform movement. See text for explanation.

regimes (or undemocratic regimes with important democratic features); two-thirds (66.7 percent) of the cases in the sample that emerged in authoritarian or primarily authoritarian contexts (excluding cultural movements, strictly defined) took the form of rebellions or revolutions or contention that was primarily rebellious or revolutionary. By contrast, about two-thirds (68 percent) of the reform movements in our sample (or cases judged to be primarily reform movements, with secondary attributes of other types) arose within democratic contexts with or without authoritarian features; 89.5 percent of the cases in the sample that emerged in democratic or primarily democratic contexts (excluding cultural movements, strictly defined) took the form of reform movements or movements primarily reformist in orientation.

That political opportunities did not matter for the emergence of any of the cultural movements, strictly defined, should not be taken to mean that opportunities are never important for cultural movements. This finding may simply reflect the fact that all of the "pure" cultural movements in our sample arose under democratic or primarily democratic regimes. Our sample also includes three cases of contention that were judged to be primarily, but not exclusively, cultural in orientation. One of these cases arose in a democratic context, while the other two arose in nondemocratic contexts—and one or more political opportunities did matter for both of the latter cases (cases 5 and 7). In short, while much more research is needed, it seems that political opportunities may be quite important for the emergence of cultural as well as other types of movements under authoritarian regimes.

Which type of opportunities, or combination of opportunities, is most important for the emergence of political contention and for specific types of contention?

The dominance of the case-study approach in scholarship on social movements, revolutions, and other forms of political contention, as well as the variety of specifications of political opportunities that have been employed by scholars, has made it difficult to discern exactly which political opportunities matter most for contention generally or for specific forms of contention. Three configurations of political opportunities account for 61 percent of all cases ($n=31$) in which one or more opportunity was causally significant. In more than a third ($n=11$), the combination of elite conflicts and elite allies helped to bring about contention; in another quarter ($n=8$), either elite allies alone or elite conflicts alone were an important factor in the emergence of contention. In other words, elite conflicts, elite allies, or the combination of these two factors were causally significant in well over half the cases of contention in which opportunities mattered.

The importance of elite divisions and elite allies for contention can be gleaned from the final line of the table in Appendix A, which indicates that each of these opportunities was a significant factor in 24 of the 50 cases in the sample. In fact, there is only one case in our entire sample, among those for which opportunities mattered, in which neither elite divisions nor elite allies played an important role: the "velvet revolution" of 1989 in Czechoslovakia.

By contrast, the other two political opportunities proved much less important for the emergence of contention. Increasing access to the political system was an important factor in only 8 of the 50 cases, and declining repression was a significant factor in only 7 cases. By comparison, decreasing access to the polity was important in at least 3 cases, and intense or increasing repression was significant in at least 9 cases. Thus, the relationship between these two factors and the emergence of contention is often the opposite of the hypothesized relationship. When these factors matter at all, in other words, access to the polity and repression seem to have a curvilinear relationship to the emergence of contention.

The importance of elite divisions and elite allies holds across both political contexts and types of contention. Whether the political context was democratic or authoritarian, elite conflict, elite allies, and (especially) the combination of these factors were the most prevalent configurations of political opportunities, when opportunities mattered (see Table C.2). Similarly, when political opportunities mattered, elite conflict, elite allies, and the combination of these factors were the three most prevalent patterns of political opportunities across all types of political contention (see Table C.3). (A partial exception to this generaliza-

tion is the finding that the combination of all four opportunities was important for reform movements more frequently than elite divisions or elite allies alone, although it was less frequent than the combination of elite divisions and allies.)

The importance of both elite allies and elite conflicts may be overstated in these data. The very notion that elite allies may be important for contention implies that only nonelites can be the principal agents of contentious politics or protest: elites may form alliances with campaigns and mobilizations of various sorts, but may not, apparently serve as ordinary, rank-and-file participants, activists, or leaders in contentious mobilizations. The assumption here—erroneous in my view—seems to be that no elites would ever need to engage directly in “extrainstitutional” politics because they already have, perhaps by definition, access to political authorities. Our data, however, include a number of movements, rebellions, and revolutions in which elites (in the sense of comparatively wealthy individuals) comprised a significant or even the major share of participants. In many of these cases, however, my sense is that the analysts for this project seem to have decided, for this very reason, that “elite allies” provided a political opportunity for contention. Yet this is illogical, to say the least. Political contention that primarily or substantially involves particular elites may certainly emerge in part because of support from other elites. Yet elites who are themselves directly contending with other groups, or with the state, are surely not allying with themselves. This apparent confusion, which stems from a questionable theoretical assumption, may have produced an exaggerated sense of the importance of elite allies in our data set. Some of the chapters in this volume support my suspicion, using what I consider an overly generous definition of “elite allies.”

The importance of elite divisions may also be overstated in our data. As a number of the analysts in this project suggested to me, it is often possible to find such divisions *ex post facto*. Whether these divisions were a cause or consequence of contention, however, is not always easy to determine. Moreover, exactly *who* needs to act upon perceptions of elite divisions for one to conclude that they were a necessary or even significant incentive for, or trigger of, protest is not clear. A few key leaders of a movement or rebellion? A sizeable minority of the participants in a particular case of contention? Most such participants? It is all too easy for researchers to conclude that elite conflicts were a significant cause of contention based on their own perceptions of such conflicts or on the *ex post facto* statements of a few individuals.

To compound matters more, Jasper suggests in the Introduction that it is often difficult to distinguish elite allies from elite division. When elites join insurgents

or protestors, this alliance demonstrates elite division. But that division need not have existed before the elites made the choice to break away out of sympathy, indignation, or calculated advantage. The fully polarized, structural model of elites versus nonelites characterizes relatively few countries, as several of our authors point out. In sum, while our data reveal the strikingly consistent importance for much contention of elite divisions and elite allies, in a variety of political contexts and for various types of contention, further comparative research is required to determine for certain whether the causal mechanisms associated with these particular political opportunities come into play with such frequency.

Other Political Opportunities

The analysts involved in this project were asked to note whether any political opportunities not included in McAdam's list were important for the emergence of political contention (see Appendix B). Two such opportunities were reported.

The first set of mechanisms may be labeled “popular allies” for short. In one case—the Nicaraguan peasant movement under the dictator Somoza (see Chapter 2)—contention emerged partly because of various forms of assistance from popular organizations (trade unions, social movement organizations, etc.) and/or social circles and individuals who would not seem to qualify as “elite” allies. Indeed, more than one researcher for this project noted that it is far from clear just who qualifies as an elite. Middle-class individuals, or just the very wealthy? What about influential writers, intellectuals, and professional people? Local politicians, or only very powerful political leaders? Tarrow, for his part, emphasizes the potential importance of what he calls “influential allies” (1994, p. 88; 1998a, pp. 79–80), but this simply raises the question in a new form: What is “influence,” and who has it?

Rather than simply expanding McAdam's list of opportunities to include “popular” as well as “elite” allies—a crude distinction at best—we might do better by differentiating the causal mechanisms by which external allies of whatever sort encourage or facilitate contention by other groups. Alliances with some groups (e.g., politicians and military officers) may encourage contention because such people directly wield state power; these are the sorts of allies, of course, that most movements ultimately strive to enlist or create. Alliances with other groups or individuals (“friends in court” and other political brokers, for example) may encourage protest because such people are known or believed to have access to political authorities. Still other allies—and not necessarily

“elites”—may provide contenders with money and other material resources (such as printing presses, fax machines, guns, or safe houses). Other people (religious leaders, for example) may provide moral legitimacy or a sense of righteousness to contenders. And still others may channel activists and militants (with their strategic know-how and commitment, among other traits) into the struggles of contending groups. Thus, external allies may encourage contention through a variety of mechanisms that analysts need to be clear about.

The other causal mechanism that emerged from this research might be labeled “newly sympathetic government (or executive).” In several instances (cases 10, 20, and 24), political activists and ordinary people perceived that the government had become sympathetic to their concerns. They were encouraged to mobilize out of a belief that authorities would react favorably to organized pressure from below. This belief typically resulted from the statements of certain political leaders prior to their ascension to power or from the apparently sympathetic fashion in which certain politicians treated the demands of other contentious groups.

These types of mechanisms reflect a more strategic perspective in contrast to McAdam’s structural vision. A variety of players are capable of making numerous blocking or enabling moves, or none, in interaction with each other, yet they need not be defined as elite or insurgent from the start. These moves include statements as well as coercion, providing resources, attracting media attention, intervening in courts, and more. Future research should be sensitive to more strategic mechanisms as well as those structural ones emphasized by McAdam.

Alternative Paths to Contention

According to political-process theory, the basic causal story of the emergence of contention reads something like this: political contention (riots, rebellions, movements, and the like) occurs in part because, and when, the opening or expansion of political opportunities—that is, perceived structural changes in the polity—convinces aggrieved people with some social ties or organization (but not necessarily vast material resources) that disruptive collective action is likely to bring about certain benefits or goods. As Tarrow puts it, “contentious politics is triggered when changing political opportunities and constraints create incentives for social actors who lack resources on their own” (Tarrow 1998a, p. 2).

Political contention is frequently triggered in just this way, although, as we have noted, it also often arises when political opportunities are simultaneously

expanding and contracting. Furthermore, the research for this project suggests at least three other general scenarios through which contention may arise, none of which necessarily depends upon even the partial opening or expansion of political opportunities.

First, contenders in many cases simply do not seem to make a determination that any particular moment is especially opportune for protest, because of structural shifts in the polity or for some other reason; rather, people are so outraged or shocked by a situation that they feel morally obligated to protest immediately, regardless of the chances for success and at times despite the high risks associated with some forms of protest. In these cases, it is moral shock, intense anger, or other emotions that trigger contention (Jasper 1997). We see this in Amy Risley’s discussion of human rights activists in Argentina and James Jasper’s discussion of the U.S. Central America peace movement, as well as abolitionism (Young 2001) and anti-racist movements (Warren 2010). Middle-class people in liberal democracies seem especially likely to assume or simply take for granted that protest (at least the nonviolent type) is possible at any time.

Second, much contention occurs in response to contracting political opportunities, often in contexts characterized by intense or increasing repression. In this scenario, contention is animated by intense frustration with politics as usual or fear of imminent harm in the absence of resistance or rebellion. Contention in such cases is triggered by fear and loathing of the status quo. Indeed, much contention is primarily defensive in nature, a kind of survival strategy. We see this scenario played out in the case of the Communist Party in Alabama during the 1930s (case 9), the U.S. homophile movement during the 1950s (case 13), the Soweto uprising in South Africa in 1976 (case 29), and the Zapatista rebellion of 1994 in Chiapas, Mexico (case 49).

Finally, people sometimes engage in contentious collective action out of general concern but without the conviction that the time for protest is right. They may participate hesitatingly and be quick to retreat—precisely in order to test whether authorities will tolerate their behavior and listen to their demands. Authorities’ reactions are never entirely predetermined. In this scenario, which is not unusual in authoritarian settings, political opportunities are not seized so much as incrementally discovered or created by protest; such opportunities do not obviously precede protest but are revealed by it, and they are sometimes rapidly shut down for just this reason. We see this scenario played out in the Chinese democracy movement of 1989 (case 43) and to some extent in the revolutions in East Germany (case 44) and Czechoslovakia (case 45) later that same year.

These alternative paths to contention are of more than scholarly interest. The research summarized in this chapter suggests that political activists, organizers, and ordinary folk with an interest in contentious action need not bide their time waiting for the opportune moment for action. It indicates that opportune moments for collective action may occur more frequently than many theorists of political contention realize. Contention is often borne of an optimism generated by political openings, but it may also arise from moral outrage, disgust with the status quo, simple frustration with politics as usual, fears for the future, and/or the courage to confront intransigent rulers.

Conclusion

Is the glass half empty or half full? Any balanced assessment of the political opportunities concept must recognize both its strengths and its limitations for explaining the onset of political contention. On the positive side, some of the causal mechanisms associated with the concept have been shown to account, in part, for the emergence of a variety of forms of contention in different political settings. Elite divisions and elite allies seem especially important for contention, although, as noted, their importance may be overstated in our own data set.

On the other hand, the importance of political opportunities should not be exaggerated, as has been the tendency in much recent theorizing about contention. Either political opportunities do not matter significantly for the emergence of contention, or they only matter in conjunction with political repression, threats, declining access to the state, and, more generally, the closing down of political space. The widespread assumption among scholars that political opportunities are *necessary* for the emergence of contention is clearly mistaken.

The research summarized in this chapter and this volume hopefully sheds light upon the place of political opportunities in the emergence of many important and interesting cases of political contention and in the emergence of contention generally. On the one hand, opportunities are a key part of strategic engagement between challengers and authorities, and we need the right analytic tools for understanding them. On the other hand, McAdam's four opportunities may no longer be the most promising ones. Instead, the authors in this volume have pointed to more nuanced, microlevel, and strategic mechanisms that will do the same work better, with less confusion. This is the essence of scientific progress: crude, vague concepts are replaced by more refined, concrete ones, for which the former have been mere placeholders.

Appendix A: Fifty Cases of Political Contention

Case	Political context	Type	Political opportunities:				Notes	Principal source(s)	Analyst
			A	B	C	D			
1. Peasant subsistence revolts (France), 1789-93	NON	REB	1	1	0	0	largely defensive	Markoff 1996	J. Goldstone (see Chapter 1)
2. Antiseigneurial revolts (France), 1789-93	NON	REB	1	1	1	1		Markoff 1996	J. Goldstone (see Chapter 1)
3. Counterrevolutionary revolts (France), 1789-93	NON	REB	1	1	1	0	largely defensive	Markoff 1996	J. Goldstone (see Chapter 1)
4. U.S. anti-vice (Comstock) campaigns, 1870s-1880s	DEM	REF/CUL	0	1	1	0	substantial participation	Beisel 1997	N. Eliasoph, P. Lichterman
5. Malawi's Watch-tower movement, 1908	NON	CUL/REB	0	1	1	0	declining access to polity	Fields 1985	M. Chaves
6. Ireland's Easter Rising, 1916	NON/DEM	REB	0	0	0	0	fear of imminent repression	Ward 1980; Caulfield 1995/1963	G. Sawicki
7. Zambia's Watchtower movement, 1917	NON	CUL/REB	0	1	0	0	increasing repression	Fields 1985	M. Chaves
8. "Second" Ku Klux Klan, early 1920s	DEM	REF/CUL	1	0	1	0		Blee 1991	R. McVeigh
9. U.S. Communist movement (Alabama), 1930s	NON/DEM	REF/CUL	0	0	0	0	intense repression	Kelley 1990	J. Gerteis
10. U.S. Townsend (pension) movement, 1930s	DEM	REF	0	0	0	0	executive viewed as sympathetic	Amenta and Zylan 1991	E. Amenta
11. U.S. Alcoholics Anonymous, late 1930s, early 1940s	DEM	CUL	0	0	0	0		Kurtz 1988	K. Albright

KEY: Political context: DEM=democratic; DEM/NON=democratic with important nondemocratic features; NON/DEM=nondemocratic with some democratic features; NON=nondemocratic. Type of political contention: REB=rebellion or revolution; REF=reform movement; CUL=cultural movement; types are listed in ascending order of importance for combined types. Political opportunities: A=increasing access to the political system; B=elite divisions or conflicts; C=elite allies; D=declining repression; the number "1" indicates that a causal mechanism implied by the factor or variable is clearly important, if not necessary; "0" indicates that no such causal mechanism seems important.

Case	Political context	Type	Political opportunities:				Notes	Principal source(s)	Analyst
			A	B	C	D			
12. U.S. radical pacifism, early 1940s	DEM	REF/REB/CUL	0	1	0	0		Tracy 1996	S. Rosenbloom
13. U.S. homophile movement, early 1950s	DEM/NON	REF/CUL	0	0	0	0	increasing repression	D'Emilio 1983	A. Green (see Chapter 7)
14. Cuban Revolution, 1952-1959	NON	REB	0	1	1	0	declining access to polity	Paterson 1994	E. Linger
15. Nicaraguan peasant movement, 1955-1961	NON	REF	0	1	0	1	popular allies	Gould 1990	A. Pereira (see Chapter 2)
16. U.S.-Cuba solidarity movement, 1959-1961	DEM	REF/CUL	0	0	0	0		Gosse 1993	S. Risley
17. U.S. civil rights movement (Mississippi), 1962	NON/DEM	REF	0	1	1	0		Payne 1995	F. Polletta (see Chapter 5)
18. U.S. Anti-Vietnam War movement, 1964-65	DEM	REF	0	0	0	0		DeBenedetti 1990	K. Moore
19. U.S. farm-workers movement (Calif.), 1960s	DEM	REF	0	1	1	0	state govt. opposed to movement; federal govt. neutral	Jenkins and Perrow 1977; Jenkins 1985	D. Mattingly
20. U.S. women's movement, 1960s	DEM	REF/CUL	1	1	1	0	govt. seen as sympathetic	Costain 1992	J. Skretny (see Chapter 6)
21. Shanghai workers' movements, 1966	NON	REB	0	0	1	1	strong local elite opposition	Perry and Li 1997	G. Yang
22. U.S. Nichiren Shoshu Buddhist Movement, late 1960s	DEM	CUL	0	0	0	0		Snow 1993	G. Ho

Case	Political context	Type	Political opportunities:				Notes	Principal source(s)	Analyst
			A	B	C	D			
23. U.S. gay liberation movement, late 1960s-early 1970s	DEM	REF/CUL	1	1	1	1		D'Emilio 1983	A. Green (see Chapter 7)
24. U.S. prostitutes' rights movement, early 1970s	DEM	REF/CUL	0	0	1	0	govt. seen as sympathetic	Jenness 1993	S. Byrd
25. U.S. anti-nuclear movement, early 1970s	DEM	REF	0	0	0	0		Jasper 1990; Joppke 1993	J. Jasper
26. Salvadoran guerrilla movement, 1970s	NON	REB	0	1	1	0	intense repression	Pearce 1986	L. Ladutke
27. U.S. pro-life movement (Calif.), 1973-	DEM	REF	0	0	0	0	"moral shock" led to mass self-recruitment	Luker 1984	S. Shapiro
28. Ethiopian Revolution, 1974	NON	REB	0	1	1	1		Keller 1988	E. Harsch
29. Soweto uprising (S. Africa), 1976	NON	REB	0	0	1	0	increasing repression	Marx 1992	R. Krabill
30. Argentine human rights movement, late 1970s	NON	REF	0	0	0	0		Brysk 1994	A. Risley (see Chapter 3)
31. Iranian Revolution, 1978-79	NON	REB	0	0	0	0		Arjomand 1988; Parsa 1989	C. Kurzman
32. Brazilian farm-workers movement, 1979-1985	NON/DEM	REF	1	1	1	1		Pereira 1997	J. Hammond (see Chapter 4)
33. Hezbollah movement (Lebanon), early 1980s	NON/DEM	REB	0	1	1	0	external elite allies; increasing repression by external actors	Jaber 1997	E. Naughton

Case	Political context	Type	Political opportunities:				Notes	Principal source(s)	Analyst
			A	B	C	D			
34. U.S. animal rights movement, 1980s	DEM	REF/CUL	0	0	0	0		Jasper and Nelkin 1992	J. Jasper
35. U.S. Central America peace movement, 1980s	DEM	REF	0	0	0	0		Smith 1996a	J. Jasper (see Chapter 8)
36. Miskitu rebellion (Nicaragua), 1980s	DEM/NON	REB	1	1	1	0	external elite allies	Hale 1994	Y. Sarikaya
37. Chilean shantytown protests, mid-1980s	NON	REF/REB	0	1	1	0	intense repression	Schneider 1995	J. Olaya
38. Anti-Marcos movement (Philippines), mid-1980s	NON/DEM	REB/REF	0	1	1	0	increasing repression	Thompson 1995	K. Schock
39. U.S. postpartum depression movement, 1980s	DEM	CUL/REF	0	0	0	0	decreasing access to polity; some elite support following emergence	Taylor 1996	N. Beisel
40. U.S. AIDS activism (ACT UP), 1980s	DEM	REF/CUL	0	0	0	0	triggered by anti-gay Supreme Court decision	Gould 2009	D. Gould
41. Mexico's new left party (FDN/PRD), 1986-1989	NON/DEM	REF	0	1	1	0	access decreasing for key elites; electoral fraud in 1988	Bruhn 1997	T. Wada
42. U.S. "hip-hop" movement, late 1980s	DEM	CUL	0	0	0	0		Rose 1994	C. Bonastia
46. U.S. mythopoetic men's movement, early 1990s	DEM	CUL	0	0	0	0	some elite participants	Schwalbe 1996	S. Shapiro

Case	Political context	Type	Political opportunities:				Notes	Principal source(s)	Analyst
			A	B	C	D			
47. U.S. Christian anti-gay movement, early 1990s	DEM	REF	0	1	1	0		Bull and Gallagher 1996	T. Fetner
48. U.S. militia movement, mid-1990s	DEM	REB/REF	0	1	0	0		Stern 1996	D. Stemen
49. Zapatista rebellion (Chiapas, Mexico), 1994	NON/DEM	REB	0	1	0	0	intense repression	Collier 1994; Harvey 1995	M. Kang
50. Taliban movement (Afghanistan), 1994-1996	NON	REB	0	0	1	0		Maley 1998	E. Naughton
Total	n=50		8	24	24	7			

Appendix B: Instructions to Analysts

Please note whether, on the eve of the movement's emergence, there is evidence for:

1. Increasing popular access to the political system. Specifically, is protest viewed by challengers as more likely to succeed or to be treated more seriously by authorities because protesters have gained some access to the political system, as opposed to very little or none at all?
2. Unstable elite alignments or elite competition (such as electoral instability, inter- or intra-party competition, or state-elite conflict). Specifically, do challengers believe that protest may be less risky and more effective or influential because elites (political, economic, cultural and/or religious) have divided in some way?
3. The presence of elite allies who encourage or facilitate protest. Specifically, are certain elites strategically supporting particular challengers because these elites are contending with other elites or for some other (for example, ideological) reason?
4. Declining state repression against opponents. Specifically, do challengers believe that protest is less risky and/or more likely to be effective or influential because state repression is declining?

Also, is there evidence for expanding political opportunities other than these four? Specifically, have other changes or events occurred in the political environment that have made protest less costly to challengers and have apparently increased its likelihood of making a difference? (Please list and describe.)

Possible answers to these questions: (1) yes, (2) no, (3) just the opposite, (4) contradictory trends are evident, or (5) not discussed by the author.

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Note: This list of political opportunities is taken from Doug McAdam, "Conceptual Origins, Current Problems, Future Directions," in *Comparative Perspectives on Social Movements*, edited by McAdam, McCarthy, and Zald (Cambridge University Press, 1996), pages 23–40, which you may want to review closely (especially pages 26–29). See also the similar discussion in Sidney Tarrow, *Power in Movement* (Cambridge University Press, 1994), pages 85–89.

REFERENCE MATTER